Los Angeles Times

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MARIO TAMA Getty Images

DEMAND for AI infrastructure is fueling a boom in data centers, including this one being built in Vernon.

Request to block 20,000 ballots is again rejected

Appellate ruling calls bid unconstitutional. Federal case may go to Supreme Court.

BY KEVIN RECTOR AND BRITTNY MEJIA

A federal appeals court for the second time Friday denied a Trump administration request to block 20,000 ballots from California voters the administration alleges may be noncitizens — ruling that the administration had failed to show that "such extraordinary relief, during an ongoing election, is clearly required by law."

Trump administration officials did not immediately respond to a request for comment, including on whether it will appeal to the U.S. Supreme Court.

The three-judge panel of the U.S. 9th Circuit Court of Appeals — composed of two appointees of President Trump and one of President Biden — ruled 2-1 that the U.S. Constitution gives the state and Congress the power to decide how elections are run, and that allowing the Trump administration to "misuse" federal statutes to "prescribe" how California must process ballots would "override the plain and manifest dictates of the Constitution itself."

"Because Congress has not exercised the specific power granted to it under

[See **Ballots,** A8]

What subpoenas may mean in L.A.

The DOJ's move could hint at criminal charges, but election officials can fight back. **NATION, A6**



RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

AN OPEN voting machine is shown at Arroyo Seco Regional Branch Library in Highland Park this week.

Big Tech stocks drop amid AI sell-offs

Investors begin to question whether the massive spending will pay off soon.

BY QUEENIE WONG

Many of the top technology stocks, which seemed almost unstoppable for months, got hammered this week as fears grew that massive spending on artificial intelligence won't pay off anytime soon.

Some investors have expressed concerns that the AI rally has inflated some shares too much. Hundreds of billions of dollars are being spent on data centers and the research to build and test the powerful large language models behind AI, but it remains uncertain whether future profits will justify the investment.

Companies have yet to prove they have enough customers for the technology and, at the same time, have expressed the need to slow down the pace of development to ensure it can be safely managed.

The latest quarterly results confirmed many concerns: While high AI profits are still far off, much more spending is still required. Many investors have taken this moment to sell some of their tech shares as they wait for a clearer outlook on profits and spending.

Meanwhile, many tech companies are realizing that AI could shift customers away from other parts of their business that are more profitable.

"The disruption caused by AI is on full display during tech earnings and the uncertainty around which names and sectors will be the disruptors vs the disrupted," said Dan Ives, partner and senior managing director at Yorkville Ives, in a note Friday.

The Nasdaq 100 index plunged roughly 4%, wiping out more than $1 trillion in value. The S&P 500 dropped more than 2% on Friday afternoon.

The market is "a lot more sensitive than it might normally be," said Chris Zaccarelli, chief investment officer at Northlight Asset Management, adding that investors would rather sell

[See **Tech,** A12]

L.A.'s Black leaders wary of Bass' prospects

To fend off Raman, mayor must shore up core support by driving up turnout on her home turf

BY DAVID ZAHNISER

It was a sprawling street festival in the cultural heart of Black Los Angeles, and Mayor Karen Bass was making her campaign pitch again and again.

Standing on a stage spanning the width of Crenshaw Boulevard, Bass urged the predominantly Black audience at the annual Taste of Soul gathering to send in their ballots, telling them about her roots in South L.A. and her crusade to reduce homelessness.

"I ran for mayor because I didn't want to see our people on the streets," said Bass, clutching the microphone in 90-degree mid-October heat. "We're only 9% of the city, and we're over 30% of the people in those tents."

Bass, the first Black woman to serve as Los Angeles mayor, is in the fight of her political career, facing a vigorous challenge from Councilmember Nithya Raman, who initially endorsed the mayor only to launch her own campaign at the eleventh hour. To win the race, Bass will need to drive up turnout among the city's Black voters and across her home turf in South Los Angeles.

The latest Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies/L.A. Times poll found that Bass has closed an 11-point gap and is now in a dead heat with Raman. Yet the mayor continues to be dogged by stubbornly high disapproval numbers, leaving some of the city's Black civic leaders on edge about Bass' prospects — at a time when Black representation is already decreasing at City Hall.

[See **Mayor,** A9]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

THE RULE applies to 600 active and 1,200 idle oil wells. Above, a pumpjack in L.A.

L.A. bans production of oil after years-long fight

Ordinance ends new drilling, phases out active wells

BY HAYLEY SMITH

After a years-long battle, Los Angeles has approved a plan to end oil drilling and pumping within city limits once and for all.

Mayor Karen Bass signed an ordinance Thursday that halts new oil and gas drilling in the city and phases out existing production over the next 20 years, making L.A. the largest city in the United States to do so.

The ordinance, unanimously approved by the City Council, applies to some 600 active and 1,200 idle oil wells, meaning idle ones cannot be brought back into production.

Energy companies argue the action is an illegal taking of their property.

"This isn't a debate about whether fossil fuels are good or bad," Councilmember Traci Park said during Wednesday's meeting, noting the city has already committed to 100% clean electricity by 2035 and is investing heavily in renewables such as wind and solar. "That's why it makes sense to stop new drilling, to stop certain expansion, and to phase out existing operations. It's long past due."

The ordinance declares all existing oil and gas activities a "nonconforming use" with current zoning, meaning they can operate only during the 20-year phaseout period. Existing wells cannot be redrilled, deepened or expanded, though routine servicing and maintenance are allowed.

The action revives a ban

[See **Oil,** A14]

Feeble Congress now faces its voters

This group has passed fewer bills, done less oversight than others in modern history.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Next week's elections are widely seen as a referendum on President Trump, his team and his party, with most voters telling pollsters they seek a check on his power. But the midterms will also serve as a reckoning for one of the least productive sessions of Congress in a century.

A stunningly low 10% of Americans approve of the job performance of Congress, which has passed fewer bills and conducted less oversight than any of its predecessors in modern history, according to scholars of the legislative branch.

The biggest achievement of unified Republican control has also become one of its biggest liabilities. Deeply unpopular when signed, the One Big Beautiful Bill Act has only grown more controversial, with most Americans still unclear on what's in it — and those who do know largely disapproving of the law, which cut taxes for businesses and billionaires while adding trillions to the national debt.

A summer Politico poll found that just 8% of Americans believe the law has improved their bottom line. The bill cut billions of dollars for food stamps and over a trillion in health programs and Medicaid.

Two other significant bills passed by this Congress — the Epstein Files Transparency Act and a housing reform package targeting corporate purchases of single-family homes — ultimately became law over Trump's opposition, leaving Republicans little credit for bipartisan wins.

"It's not a partisan statement to say that the current Congress will go down in his-

[See **Congress,** A8]

It's a grudge rematch for L.A. County sheriff

Villanueva, unseated by Luna in 2022, calls department a failure as he tries to return.

BY CONNOR SHEETS

Four years ago, Robert Luna went from being a little-known retired lawman to an unlikely political force — pushing Los Angeles County Sheriff Alex Villanueva into a runoff in the June 2022 primary.

Luna went on to beat Villanueva in the general election. He's now seeking a second term running the nation's largest sheriff's department. But the tables have turned. This year, it was Villanueva who forced Luna into a runoff, and he's angling to take back his old job in Tuesday's election.

Whoever wins will be charged with a long list of priorities, including navigating tensions with the federal government over immigration enforcement and helping keep millions of people safe during the 2028 Olympic Games.

This time, Luna has a record to champion — and defend. After four years in the Hall of Justice, he is pitching himself as a steady hand working to restore the relationships and respect that he says Villanueva had tarnished, leaving a hobbled and atrophied department in his wake.

Villanueva, on the other hand, depicts the department's Luna era as a sweeping failure that has left mor-

[See **Sheriff,** A9]

Inquiry targets Trump lawyers

A federal judge calls for an investigation into a legal dispute about a golf course project. **NATION, A6**

Election coverage all in on raw data

TV news organizations will roll out additional tools for viewers who want a granular look at the vote. **BUSINESS, A10**

N. Korea linked to Binance hack

Blockchain intelligence firm says over $6 billion was stolen from world's biggest cryptocurrency exchange. **NATION, A14**

Weather

Cloudy, a shower. L.A. Basin: 71/61. **B8**

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